

ASA1

Assessment Theory and Practice

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

Method © 2026 Erik Daniel Lindquist — Course Mastery Coach, armored drill. Items drafted with AI assistance under his direction.

How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A fifth-grade ESL teacher in a district that adopted a new curriculum last year gives short, ungraded exit tickets after each lesson and uses them to decide which students to regroup for help the next day. What type of assessment is this?

- A. Summative, because any written check is summative.
- B. Placement assessment
- C. Summative assessment
- D. Formative assessment

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher needs a score that shows what each student learned by the end of a six-week unit, to report on the grade card. Which choice fits?

- A. A pre-test given on the first day.
- B. Thumbs-up/thumbs-down checks during lessons.
- C. Daily exit tickets used to regroup students.
- D. A unit test given after instruction ends.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A student who moved from another state in October receives a reading score at the 62nd percentile compared with a national sample of same-grade students. What does the score tell the teacher?

- A. The student is proficient, since anything above the 50th percentile shows mastery.
- B. The student scored as well as or better than about 62% of the norm group.
- C. The student met 62% of the grade-level standards.
- D. The student answered 62% of the items correctly.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A teacher wants to know whether each student can write a persuasive paragraph that meets the unit standard, regardless of how classmates do. Which approach fits?

- A.** Any standardized test, since all standardized tests are criterion-referenced.
- B.** A general ability (IQ) test.
- C.** A criterion-referenced task scored with a standards-based rubric.
- D.** A norm-referenced test reported as percentile ranks.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A district buys a math test from a vendor with a strong reputation; the manual reports a reliability coefficient of .92. The items are long word problems full of idioms. Newcomer ELLs score low, yet they solve the same computations correctly when the problems are explained orally. What is the main concern?

- A.** Reliability is too low for classroom use.
- B.** No concern, because high reliability guarantees validity.
- C.** Disagreement between human scorers.
- D.** Validity: for ELLs the scores reflect English reading more than math.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Students get nearly the same scores when they retake a placement test a week later, but the scores do not predict how they do in the course. What best describes the test?

- A.** Neither reliable nor valid.
- B.** Both reliable and valid, since consistency shows accuracy.
- C.** Reliable but not valid for this use.
- D.** Valid but not reliable.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

An intermediate-level English learner who joined the school’s robotics club this fall will take the state science test. Which change is an accommodation that keeps the test measuring science?

- A. Replacing the test with one covering fewer, easier standards.
- B. An approved word-to-word bilingual glossary without definitions.
- C. Exempting the student, since English learners never take content tests.
- D. Cutting each item from four answer choices to two.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	-----------------------	----------------------------------

8.

At a district that serves 12,000 students, a new family’s home language survey shows Spanish is spoken at home. The child is outgoing and chats easily in English with the front-office staff. What should happen next?

- A. Give the state’s English language proficiency screener to decide eligibility.
- B. Refer the child for a special education evaluation.
- C. Place the child in EL services right away because another language is spoken at home.
- D. Skip screening, since the child already talks fluently in English.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	-----------------------	----------------------------------

9.

A seventh grader who arrived from Brazil in second grade and plays on the school soccer team reaches the state’s proficient score on the annual English language proficiency test and meets the district’s other exit criteria. What happens next?

- A. The student retakes the initial placement screener to confirm.
- B. The student exits with no further follow-up.
- C. The student exits EL status, and the school monitors academic progress for several years.
- D. The student stays in services until earning an A in every subject.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	-----------------------	----------------------------------

10.

A district proposes holding back any third-grade English learner who scores below proficient on the state reading test. The test is given each April and costs \$30 per student. What is the strongest concern?

- A.** A single test score should not decide retention; high-stakes choices need multiple measures.
- B.** The state test is formative, so it cannot be used for decisions.
- C.** It is fine, because standardized tests are always objective and fair.
- D.** The test costs too much to use for retention.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A newcomer who arrived 18 months ago chats fluently with friends at lunch but struggles to explain the water cycle in writing. Her older brother plays in the high school band. What best explains the gap?

- A.** She is fully proficient, since fluent speech shows full proficiency.
- B.** She has built conversational English, but academic language usually takes several more years.
- C.** She likely has a learning disability.
- D.** Academic language develops first, so her writing shows regression.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which task best assesses academic language (CALP) rather than social language (BICS)?

- A.** Writing an explanation that compares two causes of an event using evidence from a text.
- B.** Reading the lunch menu aloud.
- C.** Following routine directions such as lining up.
- D.** Chatting with a partner about weekend plans.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer D Concept 1

A fifth-grade ESL teacher ~~in a district that adopted a new curriculum last year~~ gives short, ungraded exit tickets after each lesson and uses them to decide which students to regroup for help the next day. What type of assessment is this?

Target word: classify by purpose **Decides:** Results are used during instruction to adjust teaching.

A	Absolute language	Purpose and timing decide, not the written format.
B	Adjacent category	Placement decides program entry, not daily regrouping.
C	Confusion set	Summative judges learning at the end; these tickets are ungraded and ongoing.
D	Correct	It guides next-day instruction while learning is still under way.

2. Answer D Concept 1 • transfer

A teacher needs a score that shows what each student learned by the end of a six-week unit, to report on the grade card. Which choice fits?

Target word: pick the assessment for an end-of-unit judgment **Decides:** End-of-unit, reported grade = summative.

A	Adjacent category	A pre-test is diagnostic; it shows starting points.
B	Confusion set	Informal formative checks, not an end-of-unit measure.
C	Inverted operation	That is formative; it serves the opposite purpose.
D	Correct	Summative assessment judges learning at the end of instruction.

3. Answer B Concept 2

A student ~~who moved from another state in October~~ receives a reading score at the 62nd percentile compared with a national sample of same-grade students. What does the score tell the teacher?

Target word: interpret a percentile **Decides:** A percentile compares to a norm group.

A	Absolute language	Norm-referenced ranks do not define mastery of a standard.
B	Correct	Percentile rank is a norm-referenced comparison.
C	Adjacent category	That is a criterion-referenced reading.
D	Confusion set	Percentile rank is not percent correct.

4. Answer C Concept 2 • transfer

A teacher wants to know whether each student can write a persuasive paragraph that meets the unit standard, regardless of how classmates do. Which approach fits?

Target word: pick the reference type **Decides:** Judging against a fixed standard, not peers.

A	Dropped element	Drops the difference between standardized administration and the reference point.
B	Adjacent category	Measures a different construct, not the writing standard.
C	Correct	Criterion-referenced scoring compares work to the standard.
D	Inverted operation	Compares students to each other, the opposite of the goal.

5. Answer D Concept 3

A district buys a math test from a vendor with a strong reputation; the manual reports a reliability coefficient of .92. The items are long word problems full of idioms. Newcomer ELLs score low, yet they solve the same computations correctly when the problems are explained orally. What is the main concern?

Target word: name the measurement problem **Decides:** English reading load, not math skill, drives ELL scores.

A	Camouflage	A .92 coefficient is high; consistency is not the problem.
B	Inverted operation	Reliability is necessary but not sufficient for validity.
C	Adjacent category	Inter-rater reliability is a scoring issue; the issue here is what the items measure.
D	Correct	Construct-irrelevant language load weakens the meaning of the scores.

6. Answer C Concept 3 • transfer

Students get nearly the same scores when they retake a placement test a week later, but the scores do not predict how they do in the course. What best describes the test?

Target word: reverse: consistency present, accuracy missing **Decides:** Stable scores that fail to predict.

A	Dropped element	Drops the stable retest result, which shows reliability.
B	Absolute language	Consistency alone does not show the scores mean what they claim.
C	Correct	Consistent scores that do not support the intended decision.
D	Inverted operation	Swaps the two properties.

7. Answer B Concept 4

An intermediate-level English learner who joined the school's robotics club this fall will take the state science test. Which change is an accommodation that keeps the test measuring science?

Target word: accommodation vs. modification **Decides:** Access support that leaves content and expectations unchanged.

A	Confusion set	Changes what is measured, a modification.
B	Correct	Supports access to the language without changing the science content.
C	Absolute language	English learners take content assessments, with accommodations as allowed.
D	Adjacent category	Changes the difficulty, a modification.

8. Answer A Concept 5

At a district that serves 12,000 students, a new family's home language survey shows Spanish is spoken at home. The child is outgoing and chats easily in English with the front-office staff. What should happen next?

Target word: next step in identification **Decides:** The survey flags the student; a screener decides.

A	Correct	A standardized screener, not the survey alone, determines EL status.
B	Adjacent category	Language learning needs are not a disability referral.
C	Dropped element	Skips the screener that confirms need.
D	Camouflage	Social chat does not show academic English proficiency.

9. Answer C Concept 6

A seventh grader ~~who arrived from Brazil in second grade and plays on the school soccer team~~ reaches the state's proficient score on the annual English language proficiency test and meets the district's other exit criteria. What happens next?

Target word: what exit involves **Decides:** Exit criteria met; monitoring follows.

A	Confusion set	The screener is for entry; the annual proficiency test informs exit.
B	Dropped element	Drops the required post-exit monitoring.
C	Correct	Exited students are monitored (four years under federal law) so gaps can be caught.
D	Absolute language	Exit rests on state criteria, not perfect grades.

10. Answer A Concept 7

A district proposes holding back any third-grade English learner who scores below proficient on the state reading test. ~~The test is given each April and costs \$30 per student.~~ What is the strongest concern?

Target word: concern about a high-stakes use **Decides:** One score drives a major decision.

A	Correct	One score, confounded by language, is too narrow a basis.
B	Confusion set	An annual state test is summative; the issue is relying on it alone.
C	Absolute language	Standardized does not mean valid for every decision or group.
D	Camouflage	Cost does not decide whether the use is sound.

11. Answer B Concept 8

A newcomer who arrived 18 months ago chats fluently with friends at lunch but struggles to explain the water cycle in writing. ~~Her older brother plays in the high school band.~~ What best explains the gap?

Target word: explain the gap **Decides:** Social fluency after 18 months; academic writing lags.

A	Absolute language	Social fluency does not show academic proficiency.
B	Correct	BICS often comes in 1-3 years; CALP often takes 5-7.
C	Adjacent category	The gap is the expected second-language pattern.
D	Inverted operation	Reverses the typical order.

12. Answer A Concept 8 · transfer

Which task best assesses academic language (CALP) rather than social language (BICS)?

Target word: pick the CALP task **Decides:** Abstract, content-bound language with evidence.

A	Correct	Requires academic vocabulary, structure, and reasoning.
B	Confusion set	Decoding familiar everyday text, not academic language.
C	Adjacent category	Context-rich routine language, not academic.
D	Inverted operation	That is social language.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	0	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	9	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	6	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	7	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	3	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Formative vs. summative	Formative assessment checks learning during instruction to adjust teaching; summative assessment judges learning at the end.	Classifying by format (quiz, test) instead of by purpose and timing.	What the results are used for: next-day regrouping vs. a final grade.
2	Norm- vs. criterion-referenced	Norm-referenced scores compare a student to a norm group (percentiles); criterion-referenced scores compare a student to a fixed standard.	Reading a percentile rank as percent correct.	"Percentile," "compared with peers" vs. "met the standard," "rubric."
3	Validity vs. reliability for ELLs	Reliability is consistency; validity is whether scores mean what they claim. Heavy English load on a content test adds construct-irrelevant variance and weakens validity for ELLs.	Assuming a highly reliable test is automatically valid.	A content test where language, not the skill, drives the score.
4	Accommodations vs. modifications	Accommodations change how a student accesses or responds to a test without changing what it measures; modifications change the content or expectation.	Treating any help as an allowed accommodation.	"Which change keeps the test measuring the same thing?"
5	Identification and placement	A home language survey flags a possible English learner; a standardized English language proficiency screener then decides eligibility and placement.	Placing or excluding a student from services on first impressions of conversational English.	A newly enrolling student and a home-language answer.
6	Exit and post-exit monitoring	Students exit EL status by meeting state-set proficiency criteria, and schools keep monitoring their academic progress afterward (four years under federal law).	Treating exit as the end of the school's responsibility.	A student who just met the proficiency cut score.
7	High-stakes decisions need multiple measures	Major decisions (retention, placement, graduation) should rest on multiple valid measures, not one test score, especially for ELLs.	Believing standardized tests are objective enough to decide alone.	A single score tied to a consequential decision.
8	BICS vs. CALP	Conversational language (BICS) often develops in about 1–3 years; academic language (CALP) often takes about 5–7 years.	Assuming fluent social English means full academic proficiency.	A student who chats easily but struggles with academic tasks.

Course scope (public description): Assessment Theory and Practice focuses on issues central to assessment in the ELL environment, including high-stakes testing, standardized tests, placement and exit assessment, formative and summative assessments, and making adaptations in assessments to meet the needs of ELL students.